

ALLIANCE HIGH SCHOOL

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Dear Admission Committee,

REF: RECOMMENDATION FOR SWAIB OKITA OUMA, ADMISSION NUMBER 11103

I write in strong support of Swaib Okita. He is a young man I have known since his inception into Alliance High School, a top tier institution in Kenya. In his third year, the school rolled a new project of class placement where students from various classes were picked to form a new class so as to reduce the class size and hence offer a more inclusive education. While other students were shy of leaving their classes, Swaib volunteered to take part, stating that he yearned to experience the challenge of settling in a new environment and the diversity the new classmates would provide.

Swaib is no stranger to this flexibility and his ability to thrive in different environments is indisputable. Every year, the school nominates one student to participate in a two-month exchange program to *Brooks School* in North Andover, MA. Contending students are put forward by their peers, after which they are required to give a speech to the entire school convincing them to vote them for that spot. Finally, the top five candidates are vetted by a panel of teachers and school administrators. In 2016, Swaib was our school ambassador. He quickly adapted and went ahead to prove to the Brooks fraternity that his silent demeanor did not mean he was meek as he scored some of the highest marks while there. On coming back, he took it upon himself to share his experience, inspiring other students to contend for the same position. More importantly, he urged his peers to apply for other equally competitive programs such as the *MIT Launch*, a program he encountered while there. Since then, this has become a regular program in the school.

As an institution, we strive to develop an individual in all spheres of life. Swaib fitted very well in this wholesome environment. An adept reciter, he represented the school in the *German Cultural Festival* and the *Kenya Music Festival* in his first two years. In both years, our choral was ranked first. As he became more mature, his predominant focus went into leadership. He was elected chairman of his house and eventually the house captain. In these positions, he was instrumental in leading the house to winning a bull (awarded to the best overall house) for three consecutive years, ending what had been a ten-year drought. Even grander was the determination and sheer creativity that he put in to inspire his house to win. He struck a deal with *Dice*, a printing firm that agreed to print t-shirts with a bull emblem and the house motto for all house members completely free. When the entire house donned these t-shirts on that day, it was clear who was bound to win. Having served with due conscientiousness, he was elected the chairman of the general committee, which comprised chairmen and vice chairmen from all clubs, associations and our thirteen houses, in his final year.

Whilst most of his duties required that he dedicate numerous hours to them, Swaib combined these with regular opportunities to expand his scope. He was chosen to be part of a team of only eight students to attend a two-week internship program at *MODE Kenya*, a mobile phone financial technology company. As if on cue, he was then chosen to lead a team of nine to the *Sub-Saharan International Model United Nations Conference*. In the competition that included universities from many countries, the team was ranked second overall. I had accompanied them to the conference as a school official, and as such, I saw Swaib at intervals slightly inundated but still shivering with excitement as he put across his points articulately, easily winning over his opponents. Eventually, he sponsored, and drafted, the resolution paper that was tabled before the general assembly, with him being called upon to introduce and speak for the proposed paper.

During the holidays, aside from taking part in local community service projects, he attended scouting camps. As a result, he has received all proficiency badges in *Mwamba Scouting Level*, and is due to receive his *Simba* badge (the highest accolade in this stage) from the president by December 2018.

Swaib does nothing by half measure. He has a weakness for ensuring that he obtains the best. As a case in point, when he missed out on being the school captain during his year and was instead made a house captain, he felt he had failed. In an interesting turn of events, when the appointed school captain was demoted early that year, Swaib was phenomenal in counseling his former rival to get over the demotion and get back on track. I will miss his authenticity, compassion and humility. What is clear about Swaib is that he was applying himself to his studies as well as advancing his other areas of interest, while equally giving back. I have no doubt that he will approach the education in your reputable university in the same way. He has my irrefutable support.

Yours faithfully



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